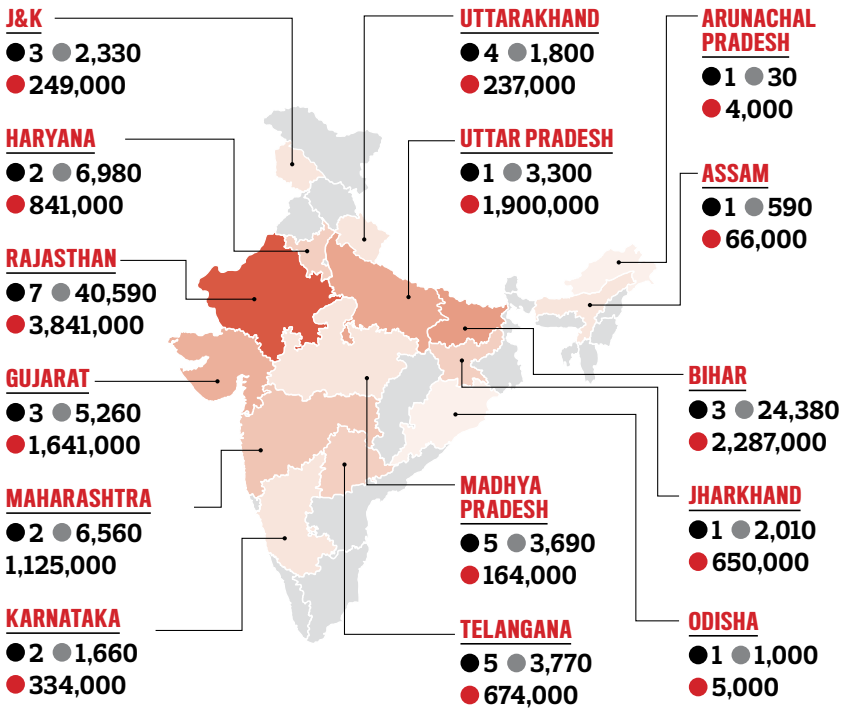
Question Marks

At least 41 government competitive exams have been compromised in the past 5 years, affecting the lives of millions of aspirants



Source: Applicants' data collected from states and rounded off

Bengal where the question paper was being printed. It was in July 2023 that the Odisha police arrested the 35-year-old Vishal Chourasia, a former accountant in the accountant general's office in Patna. Police sources reveal that he paid Rs 1 lakh to Virendra Singh Paswan, who worked at the Bengal press, to get the paper. The SSC exam was later cancelled.

This wasn't Chourasia's first such scam either—he was also allegedly involved in the leak of the question paper for the recruitment of sub-inspectors (SI) and assistant sub-inspectors (ASI) in the Central Police Organisation (which recruits for all organisations under the Union ministry of home affairs) conducted by the SSC in 2013-14.

Police sources concede that a majority of the rackets get exposed only after one or more of the accused get greedy and try to make money on a side deal or the candidates try to recoup some of the money they have spent to get the question paper by passing it on to more people. In order to prevent further leaks and to ensure that they are paid the whole amount, the exam mafia keep the original certificates of the candidates. Candidates are asked to pay half the 'fee' after the exam gets over and the questions match, and the rest once the results are declared. Once the full amount gets paid, the certificates are returned.

It's easy money, since there is no dearth of desperate candidates willing to do anything for a government job. And so everyone, whether they are a part of the system itself or outside it, is willing to do their bit for monetary consideration. In a chargesheet that the CBI filed on January 1 against 15 accused for alleged irregularities in the written exam for junior engineers (civil) for the Jal Shakti department in J&K, seven were security personnel, among them a former J&K assistant sub-inspector, an ex-CRPF head constable, an ex-army sepoy. On January 9, the central agency booked nine individuals, which included railwaymen besides officials of an Andheri-based private firm, in a case pertaining to the leak of the exam paper for the General Department Competitive Examination for junior clerks/ typists conducted by the Western Railways in 2021. On February 11, Jharkhand assembly under-secretary Mohammed Shamim and his two sons were among the 14 people arrested for the alleged leak of the question paper for the General Graduate qualified combined competition. The SSC had to cancel the third shift of the said exam on January 28.

A LONG-OVERDUE LAW

Paper leaks and exam manipulation have destroyed the chances of thousands of deserving government job aspirants who, if not done in by the scam's success, suffer on account of cancellations and endless litigation. Nothing can compensate them for the lost time and opportunities, especially at a time when government jobs are shrinking and it takes months and years for student to prepare for a competitive exam.

Indeed, so emotive had the issue of paper leaks become that the previous Congress government in Rajasthan amended the Rajasthan Public Examination (Measures for Prevention of Unfair Means in Recruitment) Act in July 2023 to raise the maximum penalty for those involved to life imprisonment. Despite this, the issue continued to simmer and was a major poll plank in the state election in November 2023. While addressing a public meeting at the time in Kota, the coaching hub of India, Prime Minister Narendra Modi had promised to punish anyone involved in paper leaks. That promise now seems to have been fulfilled. Several states have passed anti-cheating laws, but they have not had any effect. They can now perhaps look to the more comprehensive central law to rid their respective states of the menace. ■